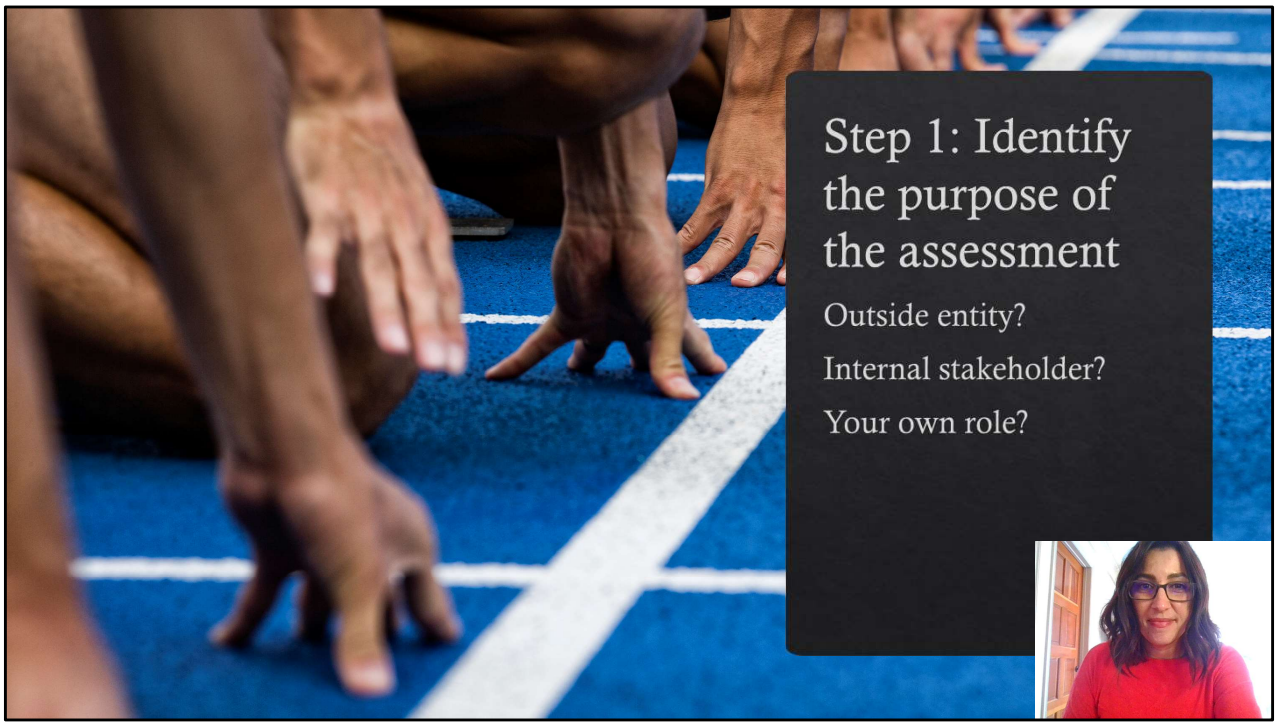
Hello! my name is Megan Bell. In this presentation I will outline 11 steps to help guide you through the assessment planning process. Thinking through all of these steps in advance will make the process smoother, less stressful and more effective.

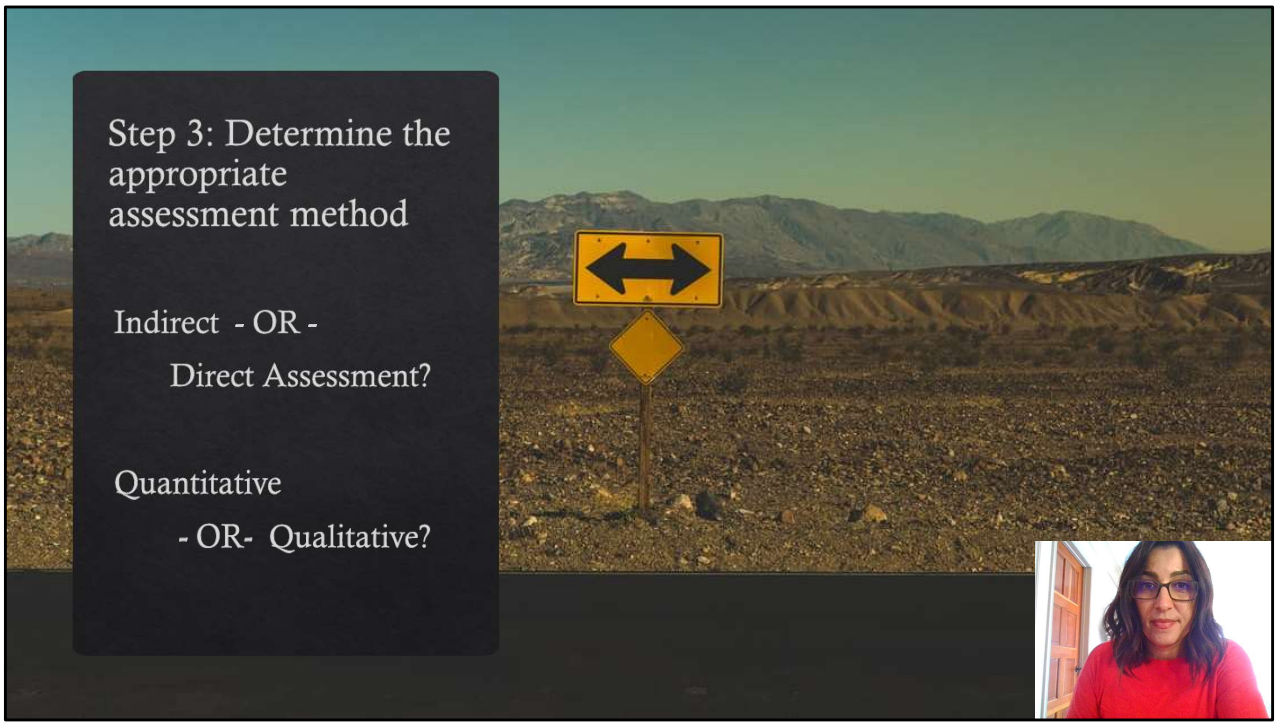
Assessment has been buzzword in higher education for years now and in many cases can be viewed with a skeptical eye. One of the reasons for this is that departments and individuals may be conducting assessments simply for the sake of doing them. Annual and program reports can look great if they are filled with data and charts, but the problem is that if no action is taken as a result of the information collected or the data are irrelevant, then the assessment initiative could have negative consequences. To prevent that, it is important to follow a logical process for building an assessment plan before you begin collecting data.



The first step of the assessment plan is to clearly identify a purpose. This purpose could stem from several different areas and depend on your own location within the organization.

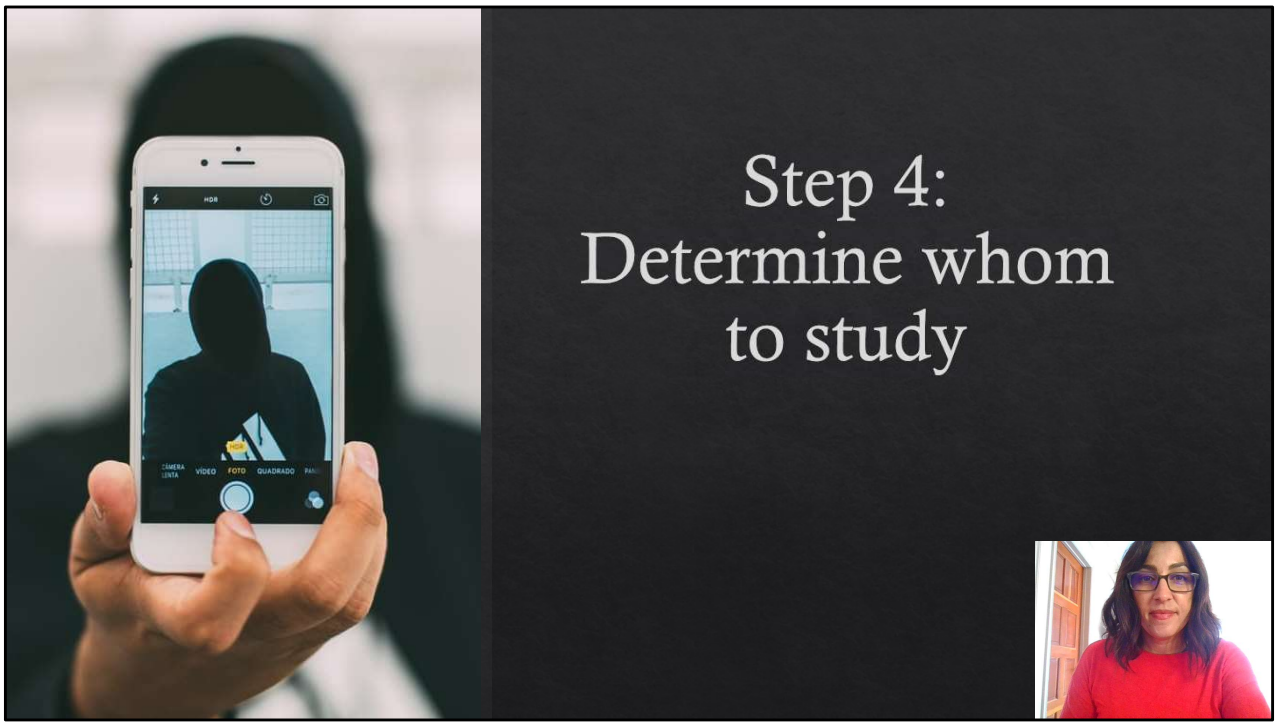
Some possible examples might be: An outside entity, such as a regional accreditor, is requiring that the university provide information on specific programs or areas. Internal stakeholders, such as a dean of students or a department director, may want to understand if their area's programs and initiatives are supporting the larger organization's stated mission and values. Your own role may require you to evaluate the impact of a program you manage to determine if it is achieving the defined goals and outcomes. And if not, what type of adjustments can be made.

After you have determined the overall purpose for your assessment you should begin thinking about where you might be able to obtain information, which is Step 2. Are there databases or other campus resources that exist that might already provide you with some information? For example, there could be another unit within student affairs hosting a focus group on student engagement. The goal is to make sure that you are considering all options before having to create your own data collecting initiative. Once you have conducted this "data audit" to find out what information you already have, you might realize that it is up to you to collect some data…



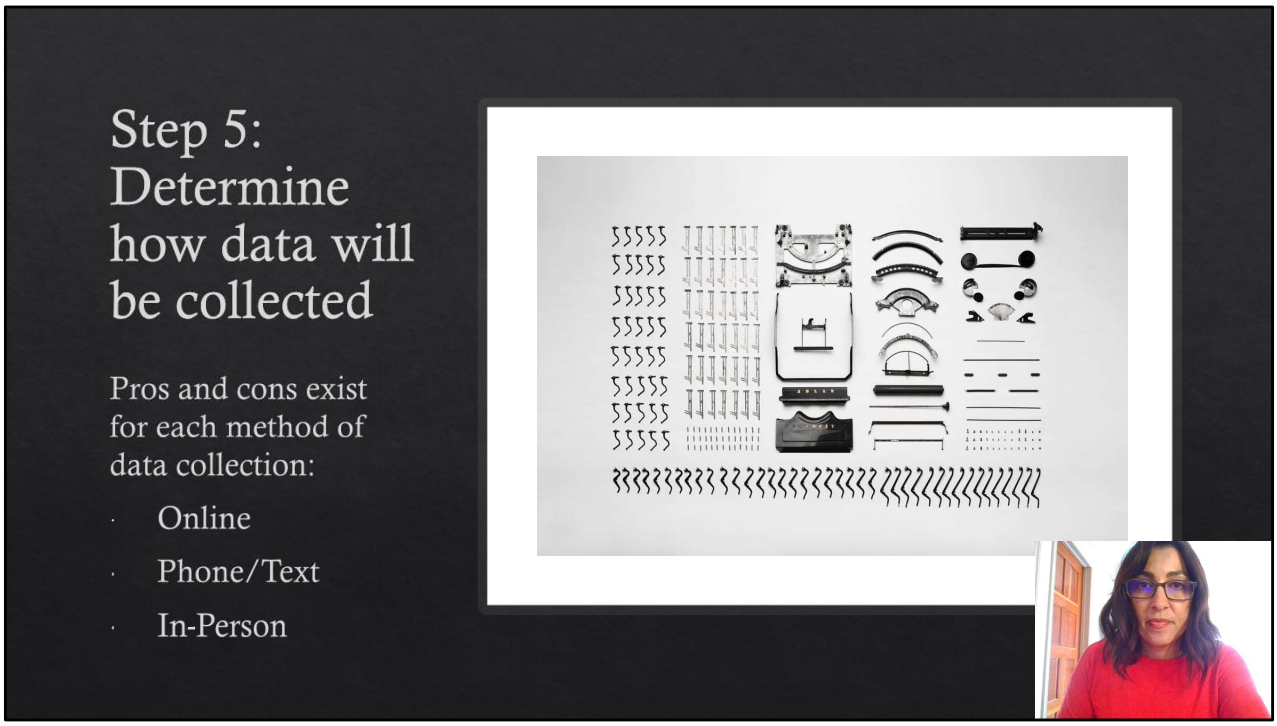
Step 3 is about determining the method. The assessment method chosen should be in alignment with the outcome being measured. There are several assessment methods to consider before choosing the one most appropriate. Assessment can be either direct or indirect. A direct assessment seeks to assess actual student performance with a portfolio, capstone, observation rubric, or a pre/post test. An indirect assessment seeks to measure thoughts and opinions of the students' knowledge or abilities (such as self-reported survey results).

The method used to collect data is critical to the overall assessment process. There are two primary methods for collecting data: qualitative and quantitative. These methods can be used individually or together, also known as a mixed methods approach. A qualitative method is direct, in-depth, time-consuming, allow participants to provide specifics and focus on words/narrative. A quantitative method is indirect, easier to report, less of a time commitment, can be generalizable, and focuses on numbers.



Step 4 answers Which population will generate the information you are seeking to find? The target population of the assessment must be in alignment with the purpose of the assessment. For example, if you are curious to know how student club leaders are engaging in workshops offered through the Office of Student Leadership, then the assessment would only be given to those students who hold a leadership position in a registered club or organization.

While it may seem obvious with the example above as who should be included, it is critical to use a lens of equity when considering who may be left out or not represented in your sample. You will want to ensure that the sample is as representative as possible of the larger population and to think critically about who will be included before data are collected.



Data collection can happen through a variety of methods. Deciding this is step 5. Which method is chosen can depend on resources, time, and the questions one is trying to answer.
Information can be collected online, over the phone, or in-person.

1. Data can be collected **online** through instruments such as surveys. There are several benefits to collecting data this way:
    1. You can reach a large number of participants.
    2. If you are using a software program, such as Qualtrics, you can schedule reminder emails to non-responders.
    3. When the collection period has closed the data are typically organized for you.

    There are also drawbacks to collecting data this way:
    1. Participants could be less inclined to provide information / it is easy for them to "delete" and move on
    2. Unless additional assessments or follow-up is done, there is no ability to ask clarifying questions about information provided

2. Data can also be collected over the **phone or via text**. This may increase

the likelihood of participants to respond, however there are several drawbacks:

1. It requires training of the phone callers or those responding to text messages.
2. There is more time required to collect the data, and more staff resources needed.
3. The data could require additional organization after the collection period has closed. For example, if the conversation goes off course or the respondent bounces around, the caller may not be sure where or how to record the information.

1. Data collected **in person** increases the likelihood of obtaining information from an individual. This can be done by handing out surveys at events or classes, conducting individual interviews, or running focus groups. The drawbacks to this method are the same as those done over the phone, where facilitator training is needed and additional work may be required to enter and organize data.

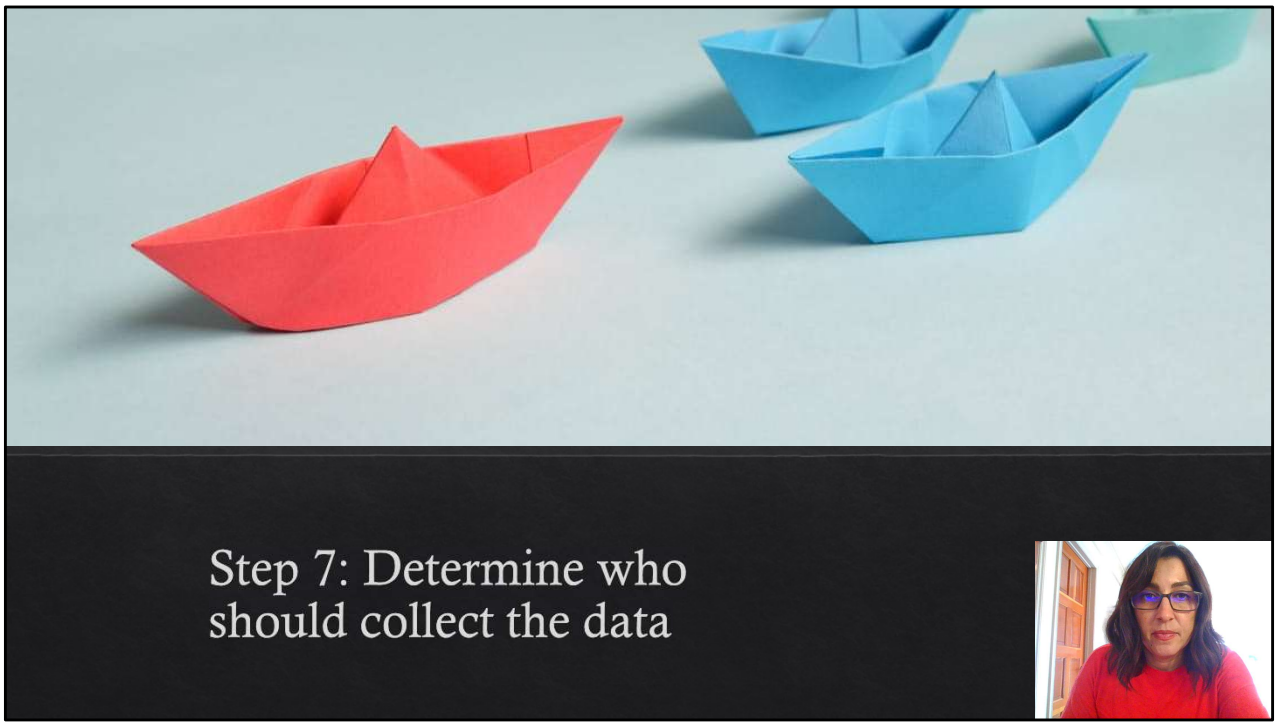
Step 6 is about the Instrument. The instrument is the basic device through which one collects the information. The instrument needs to make sense for how data collection will take place and for whether the researcher is conducting quantitative or qualitative information. Some of the most common instruments used are surveys, interviews, and focus groups.

1. Surveys are a good example of an instrument that can collect quantitative data from a large sample group. These can be done online, in-person, or over the phone.
2. One-on-one interviews with open-ended questions are a good example of an instrument that collects qualitative data.
3. Focus groups have some similarities to individual interviews, but group dynamics and moderator skill levels can impact the assessment.
4. Observations involve asking participants to complete a specified task while watching them to better understand their processes, behaviors, and modes of operation.

Consider the pros and cons of each instrument when thinking about your

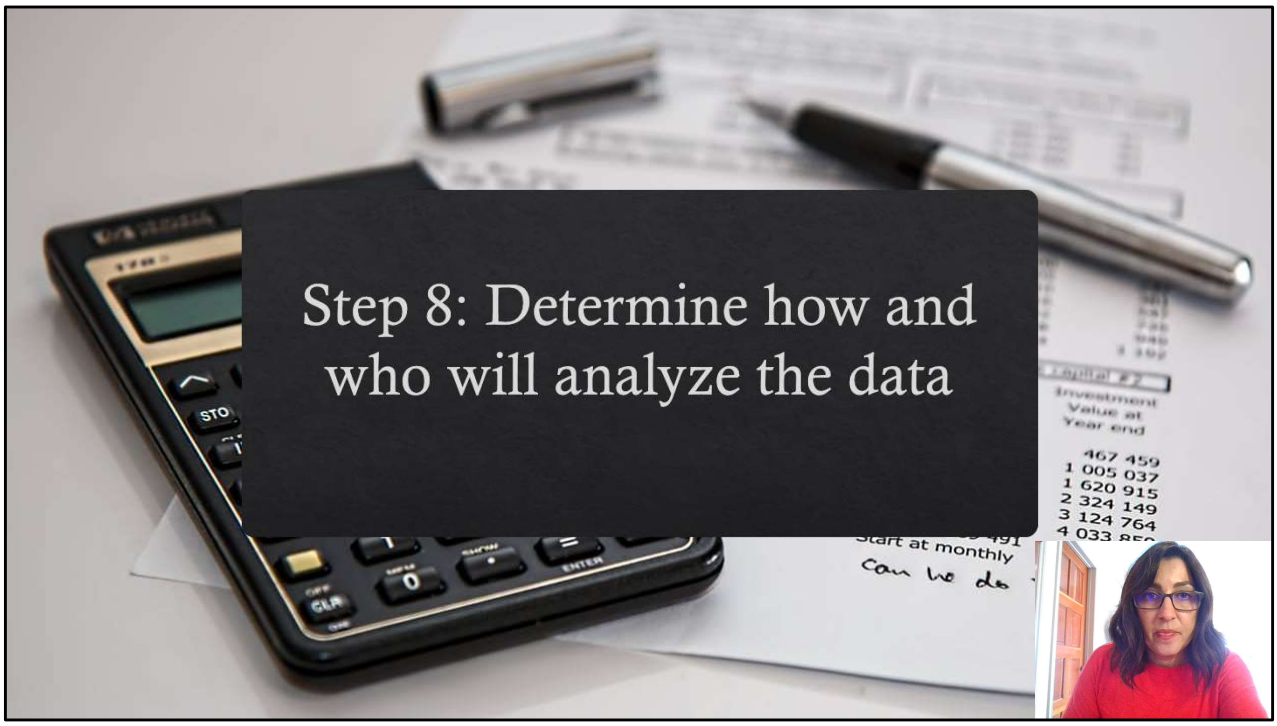
particular assessment situation, as well as what other assessments have been conducted within the same timeframe. This is to avoid survey fatigue or poor response rates.

You should also think about your instrument with a lens of equity. What questions have you chosen to ask and why? How will the instruments and questions be received and understood by the participants?



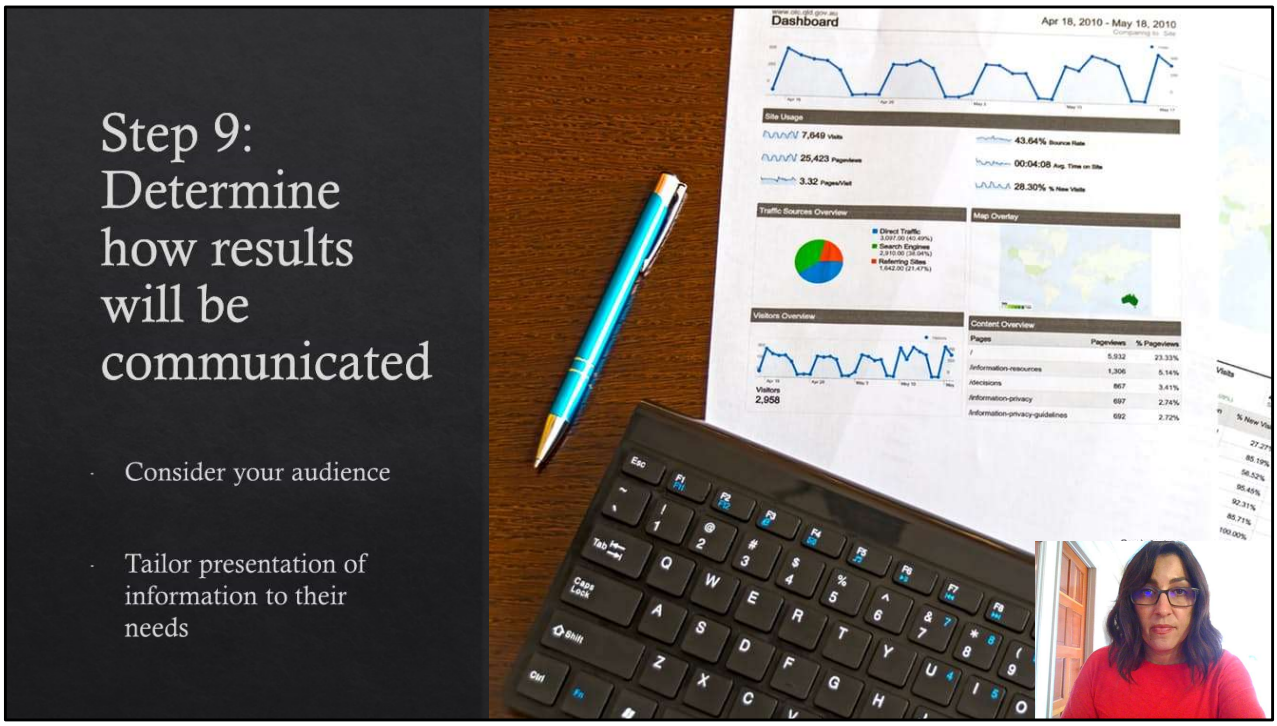
Step 7: Who Should Collect the Data? While it may seem that the person or unit driving the assessment should also collect the data, that is not necessarily always true. For example, if a focus group is being conducted with a group of students, it may be helpful to have an outside person not connected to the program being discussed lead the group. This helps to make the participants feel like they can truly speak their mind. The leader/facilitator also is less likely to be influenced by what participants say.

If a survey is being administered, consider who the participants will receive the invitation from. It may make sense for participants to receive the notice from someone they are familiar with, such as their academic department chair, instead of a campus office they have little interaction with.



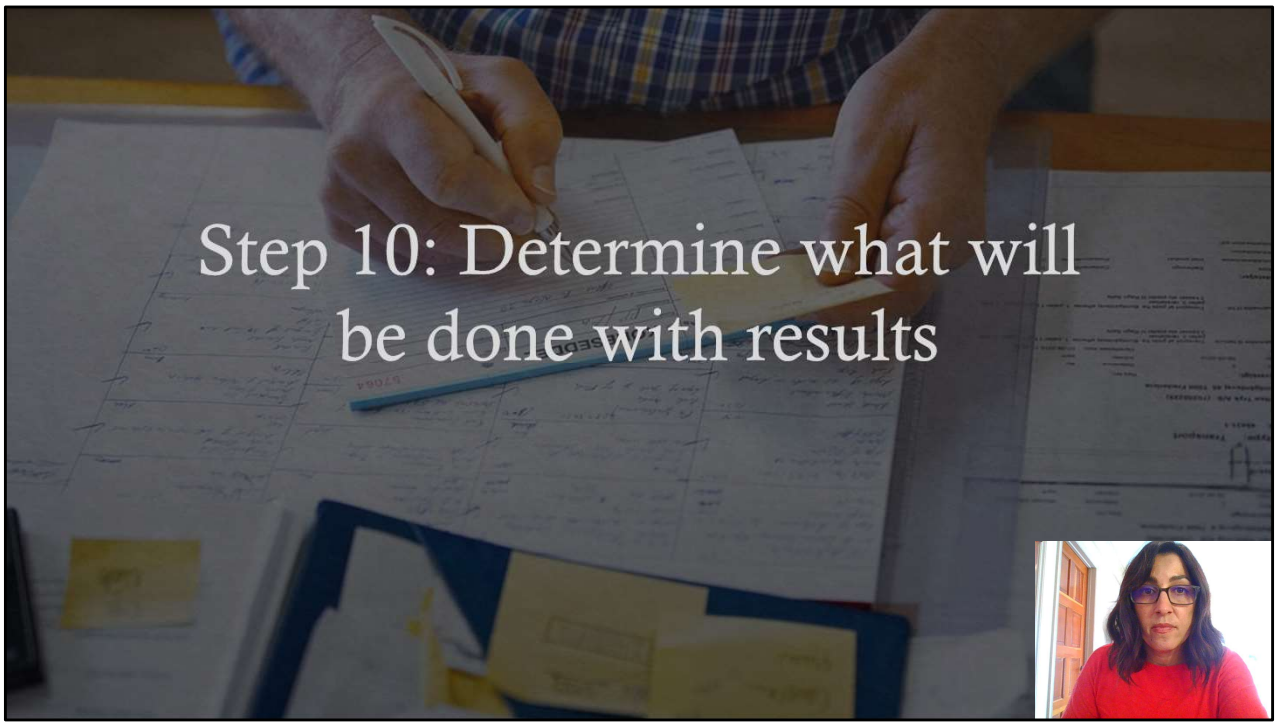
Step 8 is about Analysis. Analysis of the data is based on the method and instrument chosen. However, all data must be written in a way to demonstrate the evidence and results of the assessment given. This may include working with individuals who have expertise in analyzing data. Analysis of qualitative data involves finding common themes and trends.

Analysis of quantitative data may be more involved than just descriptive statistics, so you might explore what resources you have available to you to conduct inferential statistics.

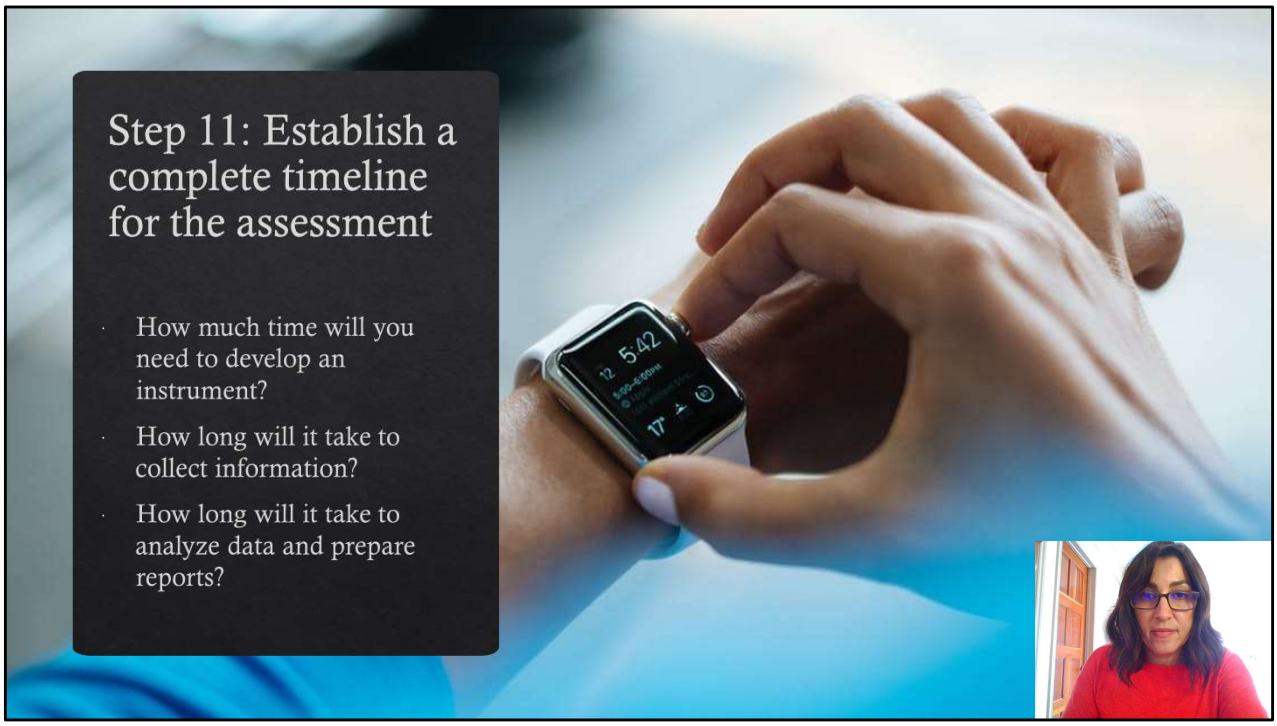


For Step, 9, Consider the audience or audiences for the information gathered as a result of the assessment. What is the most appropriate way to communicate with them? Is it a formal report with straight-forward graphics or is it a slide presentation with visually interesting graphics and video content? The goal is to convey the results in an impactful way that works for the particular stakeholders involved.

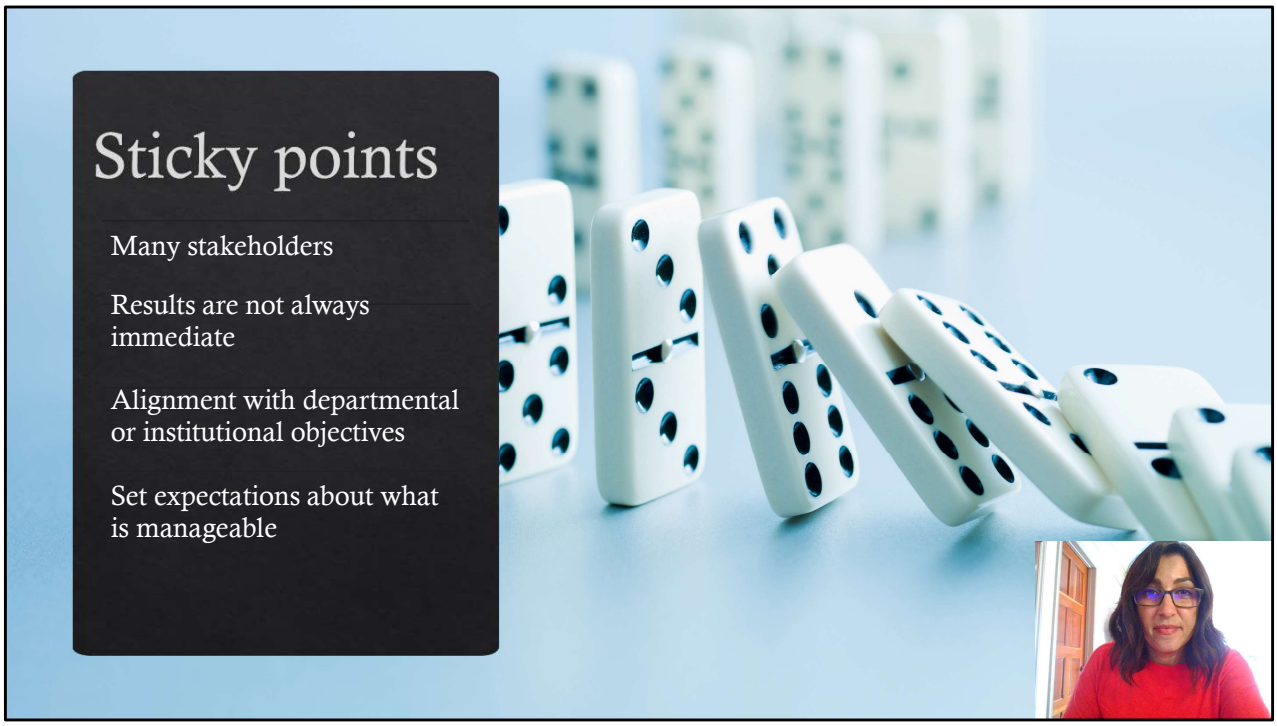
Sometimes multiple formats are required if there are multiple audiences. And remember less can really be more! Too much detail can sometimes overwhelm and confuse stakeholders.



Build a plan for what the next steps are beyond the assessment, which is Step 10. Will this assessment influence department policies or will it impact the planning of a specific program in the future? Write out the plan for taking action on the information before conducting the assessment. This part is often missed. If you are not clear from the beginning with what you will do with your assessment findings then it's easy for them to get lost or not prioritized.



And finally, Step 11. Now that the entire process has been thought through, build a project schedule with key dates. Allow time for building or selecting the instrument, and reviewing it with peers and/or students, for data collection and then data analysis, and finally for the reporting of results. Once a timeline is built, commit to stick to it so that nothing is rushed.



Assessment planning requires an extensive amount of time, detail, and many different stakeholders to ensure effectiveness. As many institutions are currently facing financial limitations, it is important to remember to make every effort to maximize the use of existing information. This not only prevents spending unnecessary time and effort, but it also helps prevent duplication and survey fatigue among students. Assessment planning can be overwhelming as there are so many moving pieces and you may find that you don't know how to keep organized. It is typically helpful to create some form of template to help guide you through all the different steps. You can find examples in the resources section for this module.

Assessment also is a long-term process, where results may not be available immediately upon the conclusion of a program. An approved assessment plan and defined timeline helps to communicate to all stakeholders the expectations for timing and the format of results or recommendations.

It is critical to be sure you are aligned with other departmental and institutional objectives so that your assessment endeavors are supported within your organization.

One final thought: you might need to acknowledge and be up front that you can't assess everything at once… and it may require you to map things out over several semesters. That is okay but be sure to communicate that with all stakeholders so expectations are known at the beginning.